Press Release for Wednesday, November 15, 2023

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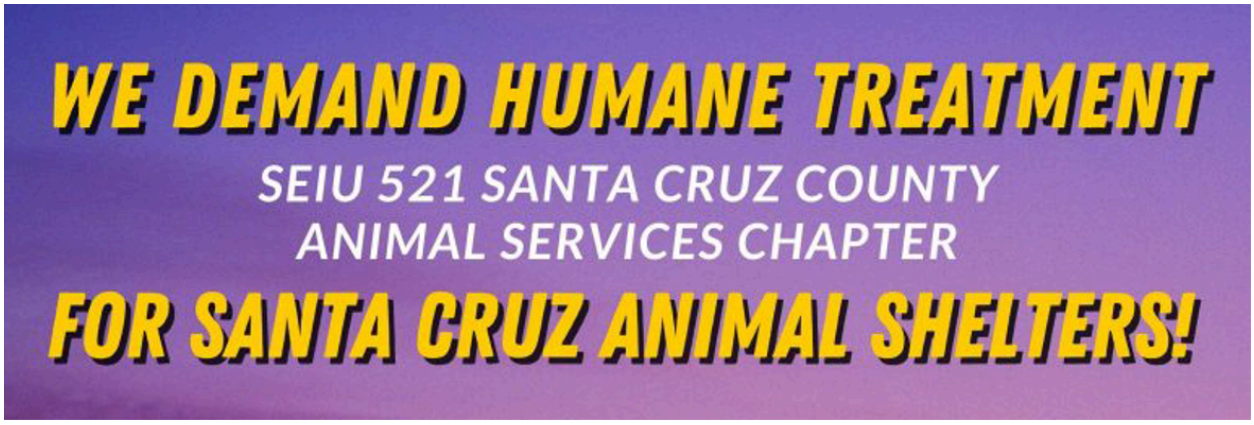

SEIU 521 Animal Shelter Union Files Unfair Labor Practice (ULP) Complaints to Combat Inhumane Shelter Operations

Shelter Workers filed several ULP complaints with the California Public Employment Relations Board to protest unsafe working conditions and unilateral changes implemented by shelter management degrading animal care.

Desplace abajo para versión en español

Santa Cruz, CA - On Wednesday, November 15, 2023, at 9 A.M, a coalition of union workers, community members, and non-profit groups filed a set of labor complaints with the *California Public Employment Relations Board* (PERB).
In a recently published Op-Ed, shelter workers and volunteers shed light on mismanagement and community demand for humane treatment of mistreated animals, workers, and volunteers who keep the shelters running.

Key issues raised in the complaints include:

1. Kennel Space and Temperature Conditions

- Lack of available kennel space due to predictable birth surges
- Kennel spaces can exceed 80°F; some areas poorly-ventilated

2. Poor management and Hiring Practices

- *Failure to hire an on-staff Veterinarian during the last two years citing pandemic budgetary constraints*
- *Defunding positions designed to develop and expand spay/neuter programs and control animal overpopulation.*
- *Several programs were eliminated or defunded to pay for exorbitant management and director salaries as well as salary incentives.*

3. Overworked and Understaffed

- The shelter is currently at overcapacity with a 6,600 projected spike of stray, abandoned, lost, and neglected animals.
- Animals are unfortunately expected to overrun available department resources and volunteer labor this year.

4. Volunteer reliance

- *Volunteers often perform work that should be handled by paid staff.*
- *Volunteers will go outside of County if the shelter requests special medical services for animals under their care.*
- *Volunteers are not compensated for their transportation.*
- *Volunteers contributed almost 7,000 hours of labor from June to August 2023.*

"We are at a point where management's dereliction of duties, incompetence, and poor judgment are making the Shelter's animal care, staffing, and safety issues much worse. "-**SEIU 521 Member and Animal Services Coordinator, Jillian Ganley**

"When the Board of Supervisors underfunds and short-staffs Animal Services, they willfully neglect their commitment to provide care to mistreated animals. Our staff will fight for every resource being eyed by our managers and Board of Directors and Santa Cruz County Board of Supervisors for themselves to ensure the doors remain open for our community."-**SEIU 521 Animal Services Coordinator, Megan Carroll**

WHAT:

Demand A Humane Shelter for Santa Cruz County Animals, Volunteers, and Staff!

We urge you to circulate our current petition to advance humane animal treatment in Santa Cruz County:

https://www.seiu521.org/wedemandhumaneshelters/

WHO: Service Employees International Union Santa Cruz County Local 521 members, Animal Shelter volunteers,

WHY: The County must invest in community services to alleviate structural inequalities, animal control outcomes, and provide resources for animal treatment. Shelter managers' underfunding and understaffing of animal welfare programs, including the cancellation of Planned PEThood, force heavy reliance on volunteers, compromising the overall quality of operations.

SEIU 521 Animal Shelter workers are immediately available for interviews.

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Service Employees International Union, Local 521 represents 53,000+ public- and nonprofit, private-sector workers in California's Bay Area, the Coast, and Central Valley. Under a Community First vision, we are committed to making sure the needs of our community, and the vital services we provide our community, come first. We believe our communities thrive when residents, elected leaders, and workers recognize that we are all in this together when it comes to our safety, health, and well-being.